crucial Home department to his alliance partner. Instead of trying to be an immoveable object against an unstoppable force, his playmaker instincts told him to redirect energies in a lateral direction. Thus the sweeping administrative reorganisation last announced last month, aligned to his governance objectives and popularly felt needs.

### JOBS IN THE FOCUS

Three new departments were born to that initiative: Youth, Employment and Skill Development; Higher Education; Civil Aviation. The intent is clear. Unemployment, the big red flag that Nitish's cavalcade managed to evade during polls, is no longer to be ignored. That got an enabler with a new Directorate of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises under the Industries Department. Alongside, the new Bihar Marketing Promotion Corporation will seek to bridge the chronic gap between production and market access.

**Takeaways**

- **Nitish harps on the 'bad old days' of RJD, backs it up with an ambitious governance roadmap**
- **3 new departments, 1 directorate to spur industry, job creation; citizen audit for administration**

Nitish has also been outlining the third run of his Saat Nischay—an ambitious five-year agenda that aims to rev up industrialisation, double Bihar's per capita income, provide jobs to 10 million youth and establish degree colleges across districts. Questions are seldom invited in his public interactions, but a degree of formalisation is being built into the public audit of policy. Every Monday and Friday has been fixed for administration-citizen interfaces: officials across the hierarchy, from panchayat and district HQ offices to state departments, are to be physically present to record complaints. Will it do the job? Time will tell. But it catches Nitish in a maestro moment, meeting political fluidity with governance structure. ■

▶ TAMILNADU

# DISRUPTOR TWEAKS THE DRAVIDIAN SCRIPT

**Vijay, the new show in town, is altering equations for all sides in the Tamil Nadu pre-poll heat. Neither the DMK, nor the AIADMK is entirely immune to his vote-slicing potential**

*By* **Kavitha Muralidharan**



**A LOT OF EYES THESE DAYS ARE** following a moving line in Tamil Nadu: the new X-factor that has emerged in the shape of actor Vijay and his Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK). Attempting to carve out an independent path—a rare 'third option' for an electorate long trapped in a binary—he's being judged, in early estimates, to have more wind in his sail than is usual for political forces that do not swim with either of the two main Dravidian fronts.

It doesn't hinder Vijay's chances that the headlines are full of him these days: a new symbol allotment (the whistle), summons from the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) over the Karur stampede in September, censor trouble over a film meant to put him in orbit ahead of voting, alliance talks.... From all the complex signalling, his political identity is beginning to acquire sharper outlines.

Which leaves the bigger picture hazier. For one, of late, Vijay has moved from selective criticism—targeting only the ruling Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK)—to being an equal-opportunity offender, openly hitting at the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) too. With his unquantified vote share potential, this is giving the upcoming assembly election an unpredictable shape. The long shadow of the Karur stampede, which occurred during a TVK event and resulted in 41 deaths, seems to have destabilised past equations.

### FRIENDSHIP SOURS

In its immediate aftermath, the AIADMK had backed the TVK, effectively preventing it from being isolated politically, even inviting it for an anti-DMK front. For months, Vijay, too, was tactically reciprocating; indeed, he even managed to blame the DMK for allowing space to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) , calling it an "indirect surrender", while giving